the OBCs, is the bedrock of the BRS. What the opposition could do is articulate issues that fire up the imagination of the voters. Anti-incumbency from two terms in office is a serious challenge for KCR.

A SHAKY OPPOSITION

Infighting is a constraint for both the Congress and the BJP. State party chiefs A. Revanth Reddy of the Congress and Bandi Sanjay of the BJP are the most visible faces of thir respective parties. The BJP is also on the backfoot after its loss to the BRS in the high-voltage Munugode bypoll—the incumbent MLA had resigned from the Congress and joined the saffron party to contest on its ticket. Finding suitable candidates for all 119 constituencies itself will be a major challenge for the BJP. The Congress is relatively better-placed in this regard. The resounding win in Karnataka has energised party veterans in Telangana, who are raring to go. This, of course, is causing some anxiety in the 'pink party'. The BRS is apprehensive of a cross-border ripple effect damaging its prospects, especially from the contiguous Hyderabad-Karnataka region. South Telangana is especially vulnerable, which is why KCR has of late been stressing to senior BRS leaders that the Congress is their main rival. This is despite him running down the BJP at every opportunity in recent years. The KCR camp says this is a tactical move to ensure a split in the opposition vote.

For the saffron party, even the (Narendra) Modi factor will have limited appeal outside Hyderabad in the absence of strong local leaders. The BJP will find it difficult to sell it here. "The notion of a double-engine *sarkar* is essentially for centralised development rather than people-centric development. It negates the concept of development and welfarism going hand in hand. This is the reason why the BJP was perceived as the party of the rich and the Congress that of the poor in Karnataka," says Venkatesu.

Though social engineering has its pitfalls, political parties are ready to take the gamble hoping for en bloc voting. For the Congress and the BJP, the challenge is to woo the backward classes drifting away from the BRS. To compensate for the loss, KCR is focusing on Dalits with the unique Dalit Bandhu investment support scheme that gives a grant of Rs 10 lakh to launch a business.

Keeping OBCs on their side is crucial for any party to win in Telangana. In this, the Congress appears to have an edge having already demanded a nationwide census of the OBCs. "The strong assertion of the OBCs counted significantly for the Congress win in Karnataka and could be vital if it reaches similar critical mass in Telangana," says Venkatesu.

The single-caste, single-family driven politics of the BRS will also have its limitations now that the euphoria of statehood is on the wane. This is notwithstanding the KCR regime's attempts to keep it alive, such as putting up a new Telangana Marytrs Memorial to eclipse the one installed earlier.

CHALLENGES FOR THE BRS

- **Battle growing anti-incumbency** The party has been in power since Telangana came into being in 2014
- **Find funds for schemes** The party can ill-afford to scrimp in an election year—Rs 34,700 cr. earmarked just for Rythu Bandhu/ Rythu Dalit schemes
- **Counter corruption charges** Opposition has red-flagged Dalit Bandhu and many other schemes
- **Divide Opposition vote** BRS will explore all means—including poaching viable leaders—to ensure neither Congress nor BJP gain traction

THE GRAFT TEST

The Congress has consistently levelled charges of corruption against the BRS to drum up support. "Corruption is there, but there's no public spectacle to point fingers at," says Vageeshan. "That said, if it gains currency, it could be a debacle for KCR." The BJP has also levelled similar charges, including on the leak of recruitment exam papers of the Telangana State Public Service Commission that has now delayed prospects of government jobs for many. Even in the Dalit Bandhu scheme, there are allegations of MLAs asking for a 30 per cent cut from beneficiary families.

The Congress's problem is its armchair politicians who have to make way for the next-generation aspirants in the party. As for the BJP, its plans to woo leaders from other parties has failed to gather momentum. It had few resourceful candidates of its own in the byelections, and the two contests that it won, it relied on defectors from the BRS and the Congress. The calculation that a Congress crash in Karnataka would lead to a mass migration of party leaders in Telangana has also failed to materialise. Now it faces an uphill task finding worthy contestants.

Trying to polarise the vote using Hindutva tactics has also ceased to yield political dividend. "Even children find it laughable that they chose to rename Karimnagar as Karinagar in party posters and banners for the Hindu Ekta Yatra rally held on May 14," says Vageeshan. The BRS hasn't been quiet on this front either, putting Dalit historical icons in the forefront by installing the biggest statue of Dr B.R. Ambedkar and naming the new state secretariat after him in April.

Despite the challenges, the BRS seems at an advantage as the index of opposition unity is low, though Congress prospects have brightened post Karnataka. KCR, in his usual hyperbolic style, likes to say his government has 'reinvented, rediscovered and reconstructed' Telangana in recent years. The shine may be dimming, but it could just be enough to carry the BRS over the finish line one more time. ■